

House Hacking, One Page

Everything that matters, on one sheet. Keep it. Show it to whoever you'd be doing this with.



IN ONE SENTENCE

You live in one part of your property and rent out another — lowering your housing costs while you build equity, in the same house, at the same time.

THE FOUR MODELS

MODEL	EFFORT	PRIVACY	INCOME	BEST FOR
Spare bedroom / room rentals	Low-High	Low	Low-High	Fastest start, lowest cost
Basement / in-law suite	Medium	High	Medium	Most common in Atlanta metro
Small multifamily	Low	Highest	Medium	Cleanest separation, hardest to find
ADU / detached	High upfront	Highest	Med-High	Adds long-term property value

Room rentals scale — one housemate is the simplest version; a full coliving house is the most operational and highest income. **Two variables apply to all four: Furnished** (higher rent, more capital, shorter stays) or **unfurnished** (simpler, longer stays) · **Long-term** (most passive) / **mid-term** (the sweet spot for many) / **short-term** (highest return, most work).

WHY IT WORKS — THE FINANCING

When you buy a property you'll **live in**, you get a much smaller down payment, a better interest rate, and easier qualification. An investor buying the same house gets none of that. **That gap is the entire mechanism.**

And the loan doesn't stop being an owner-occupant loan when you move out. Live there for the period your loan requires, then rent the whole thing — and do it again on your next primary residence.

THE FOUR NUMBERS

- What it actually costs to own** — P&I plus taxes, insurance, mortgage insurance, HOA, utilities you cover, and a maintenance reserve
- Realistic rental income** — what comparable spaces actually rent for, minus a vacancy allowance. Not best case
- Your effective housing cost** — #1 minus #2, compared to what you'd otherwise pay in rent. *Zero was never the benchmark*
- What it looks like when you move out** — does it cover itself once you rent the whole thing?

Run them in order. Each one can end the analysis.

WHAT MAKES A GOOD PROPERTY

Separation beats square footage. The whole walkthrough is one question: *can two people live here without constantly being in each other's way?*

Look for

separate entrance · tri-level or multi-zone layouts · good bathroom-to-bedroom ratio · parking that actually fits · storage · room for a second fridge

Be careful with

open-concept · single-story · one bath for four bedrooms · "already finished" basements · "could easily be converted"

THE OPERATING RULES

Be rigorous about systems. Be warm about people.

- Same application process for **everyone**, every time — no exceptions for friends of friends
- Written lease, even for one room. Automated rent collection from day one
- Say the awkward things before move-in: guests, noise, shared space, kitchen, cleaning, parking
- Fix small things fast — it sets the tone for the whole house
- Reserve a percentage of rent monthly for maintenance, and treat it as spent

An empty room costs one month. The wrong person costs months. If you're not sure about someone, that's your answer.

THE LONG GAME

Your housing cost drops → **that gap becomes your savings rate** → equity builds → a few years later you have a down payment and real experience → you move out, keep it as a rental, and do it again on owner-occupant terms.

Automate the gap out of your account the day rent lands. Otherwise it disappears into ordinary life and you'll have nothing to show for it. The first house is hard. The second one is a completely different experience.

START HERE

- ☐ Talk to two or three lenders **before** you look at houses
- ☐ Define what you're comfortable sharing — honestly
- ☐ Run the four numbers on a property you won't buy
- ☐ Come to a meetup

*Live for less. Build more wealth.
Every door is an opportunity.*

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